

**The Heated Rivalry Index: Viral Consumption of Salacious HBO Content as an Indicator of
Economic Downturn**

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“This (paper) is such a bad idea.” - Shane Hollander

Abstract

In January of 2025, Jacob Tierney's *Heated Rivalry* captivated an audience across the United States. Distinctive in its explicit content and elegant cinematography, the show follows the secret, gay relationship of two professional hockey players. In this paper, we view the virality of *Heated Rivalry* from an economic lens. Economists have long used unconventional indicators to predict recessions, from strip clubs to men's underwear sales (Moll et al., 2013; Kelly, 2023). This paper argues that the viral consumption of *Heated Rivalry* may serve as one such indicator; we examine the correlation between the consumption of explicit TV shows and the 2008 financial crisis. Using Granger Causality models with unemployment data, we show that the consumption of salacious TV content (coined the "Heated Rivalry Effect") predicts an increase in American unemployment one quarter ahead.

Background

Recessions are periods of economic downturn in which real GDP decreases while unemployment increases (Mateer, 2023). Negative consequences come with recessions, such as widespread mental and physical health issues (Margerison-Zilko et al., 2016) and detriments to the cognitive development of preschool children (Kalil, 2013). Given these serious implications for society, economic studies have looked at using certain factors to try to predict recessions. This includes economic indicators such as the annual return on the S&P500 (Liu & Moench, 2016), as well as more obscure indicators like McDonalds search trend data (Wang & Chen, 2018).

In this paper, we analyze a potential indicator of a recession, the popularity of *Heated Rivalry*. *Heated Rivalry* is a TV show released in 2025 (IMDb, 2025). It follows the secret, intimate relationship of star hockey players Shane Hollander and Ilya Rozanov over the course of a decade (Tierney, 2025). According to Google Trends, the show's popularity peaked in January of 2026

(Google Trends, 2026b). The show is distributed by HBO Max in the United States (HBO, 2025), and it stands out for its intense and frequent sex scenes, rated “Severe” in IMDb’s Sex & Nudity section. We will reference these features of the show in our analysis.

Literature Motivation

To analyze *Heated Rivalry*’s effectiveness as a recession indicator, we first understand the context of the show’s distribution. In the United States, the show is exclusively available through HBO Max. As such, accessing the show can be seen as a small luxury product. During recessions, people often cannot afford large luxury items, such as expensive vacations or extravagant clothes. To make up for this, people spend their money on comparatively inexpensive luxury items; an example of a small-scale luxury is high-quality cosmetics and lipstick, and we often refer to this phenomenon of small luxury spending during recessions as the “Lipstick Effect.”

HBO is also relatively inexpensive, with plans ranging from \$10.99 to \$22.99 a month. However, this cost is slightly higher than that of other services: Netflix starts at \$7.99, and Prime Video at \$8.99 (IGN, 2025; Netflix, 2025). And, given the availability of free entertainment services like YouTube, we see how the popularity of an HBO-exclusive show in the United States could indicate the “Lipstick Effect”, potentially signalling a recession.

The nature of the show is another interesting characteristic. As mentioned in the Background section, *Heated Rivalry* is rated by IMDb to have “Severe” sexual elements. The explicit scenes of the show, at least one in each episode (except Episode 5), differentiate *Heated Rivalry* from all other shows of its popularity. This characteristic connects it with recession-signalling content.

In past recessions, a significant increase in porn consumption has been observed. For example, during the COVID-19 pandemic, traffic on the most popular porn site increased by up to 23% in the US, and over 90% in other countries (Awan et al., 2021). It’s even been argued that the

Great Depression helped grow the porn industry to its prevalence throughout the 20th century (Cullum, 2016). This correlation is hypothesized to stem from porn being a method of escape from the economic hardships of reality. The incredibly sexual nature of *Heated Rivalry* serves a similar purpose; its consistent sex scenes offer an escape from reality, much needed during a recession.

Finally, through understanding the story of *Heated Rivalry*, its resonance with the American populace during a recession becomes evident. At its core, *Heated Rivalry* reflects a story of hope; over the course of a decade, our main characters go from denying their own sexualities to accepting their romantic relationship. Our main characters begin their relationship in 2008, under impossible circumstances. Ilya is from Russia, and he cannot come out for fear of his life; Shane felt the need to conform to the standards of his parents and society. Over the course of a decade, they navigate what are certainly impossible odds to develop a thriving, though still secret, relationship.

For both individuals, the circumstances they face are completely out of their control. They cannot single-handedly change the cultural norms of their society or the actions of their governments. This helplessness mirrors the fatalistic attitude adopted by those negatively affected by a recession (Kapunvári, 2011). In presenting a story in which two characters fight through a hopeless circumstance, the show *Heated Rivalry* resonates with the American populace during a recession. Thus, its popularity could reflect the widespread prevalence of a fatalist mindset, signalling a recession.

Data and Methodology

To quantify the consumption of salacious TV shows, we use monthly Google search trend data for the three shows defined as having “Severe” Sex & Nudity in IMDb’s list of “The Best TV Shows of 2007-2008” (IMDb, 2026; Google Trends, 2026a). The three shows referenced were *The Tudors*, *True Blood*, and *Californication*. We compared the data to the Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis’

unemployment data from January 2007 to December 2010, encompassing the entirety of the Great Recession (FRED, 2025). The unemployment rate used was U3, the standard metric for unemployment that includes individuals who are jobless, available to work, and have searched for work in the past four weeks.

We use the Granger Causality model to analyze the significance of predictions one to six months ahead. The analysis includes each of the three TV shows, as well as their combined Google search interest.

Results

As shown below, we see that both *True Blood* and the combined index of all three shows prove significant in predicting unemployment 3 months ahead. In particular, the combined index of all three is the most significant, with a p-value of 0.015.

We also find that the combined index of all three shows has a significant negative correlation four months ahead. This suggests that four months after the viral consumption of Heated Rivalry, the economy may experience improvement.

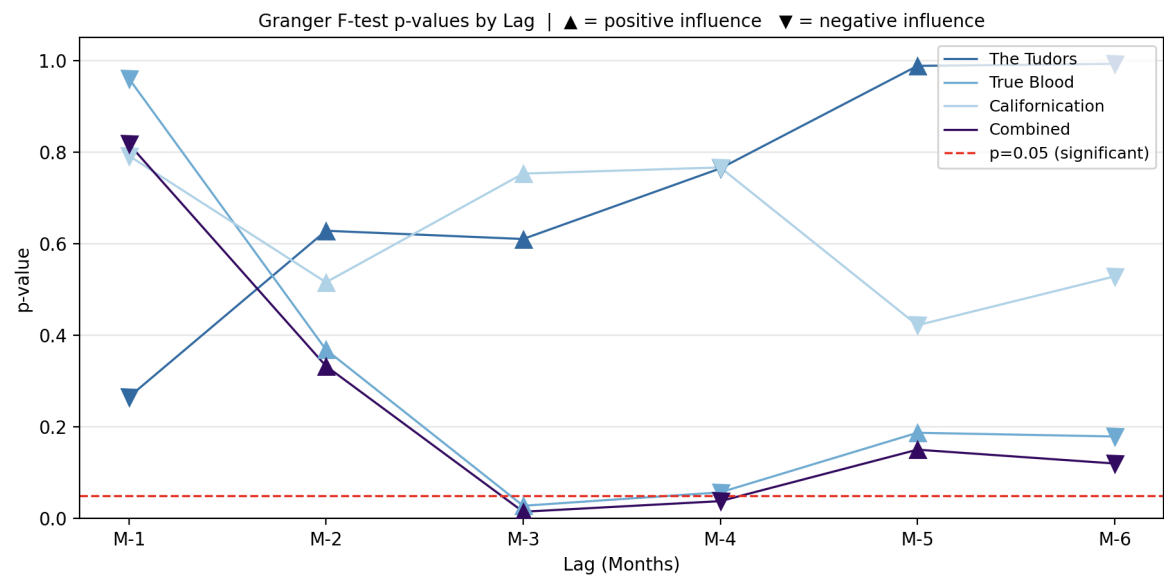


Figure 1: Granger Causality Analysis of Google Search Trends and Unemployment Data

Show	Lag 1M	Lag 2M	Lag 3M	Lag 4M	Lag 5M	Lag 6M
The Tudors	▼ Negative coef=-0.017 p=0.265	▲ Positive coef=+0.005 p=0.628	▲ Positive coef=+0.004 p=0.610	▼ Negative coef=-0.008 p=0.764	▲ Positive coef=+0.005 p=0.988	▼ Negative coef=-0.013 p=0.993
True Blood	▼ Negative coef=-0.001 p=0.961	▲ Positive coef=+0.001 p=0.369	▲ Positive** coef=+0.004 p=0.028	▼ Negative* coef=-0.001 p=0.057	▲ Positive coef=+0.002 p=0.187	▼ Negative coef=-0.002 p=0.179
Californication	▼ Negative coef=-0.004 p=0.792	▲ Positive coef=+0.001 p=0.516	▲ Positive coef=+0.001 p=0.753	▼ Negative coef=-0.000 p=0.767	▼ Negative coef=-0.008 p=0.422	▼ Negative coef=-0.018 p=0.529
Combined	▼ Negative coef=-0.001 p=0.818	▲ Positive coef=+0.002 p=0.333	▲ Positive** coef=+0.004 p=0.015	▼ Negative** coef=-0.001 p=0.038	▲ Positive coef=+0.002 p=0.150	▼ Negative coef=-0.003 p=0.120

Table 1: Granger Causality Analysis of Google Search Trends and Unemployment Data

** indicates significant ($p < 0.05$) * indicates marginal ($p < 0.1$)

Conclusion

Through our analysis, we've provided evidence that the popularity of the show *Heated Rivalry* may signal a recession. Specifically, we've shown that consumption of salacious TV content is significant in predicting an increase in unemployment three months ahead. And, we've provided literature justification for the reasons behind this effect.

Beyond its merit as an analytical predictor, the show's representation of LGBTQ+ struggles with acceptance is incredibly crucial, particularly in the context of a recession. It's been shown that, during recessions, the physical and mental health of sexual minorities deteriorates (Drydakis, 2021). Combined with elements such as social and family rejection, recessions are exceptionally difficult for sexual minorities. By providing a source of hope and representation during a recession, *Heated Rivalry* shows us that one day, we'll all make it to the cottage.

Applying our findings to the popularity of *Heated Rivalry*, the show peaked on January 11th of 2026 (Google Trends, 2026b). As such, since we've rigorously proven it predicts a recession 3 months ahead, the stock market will crash on exactly April 11th, 2026.

Endnotes

The academic sources referenced in this paper were obtained via Google and Google Scholar searches. Keywords searched include “recession indicators”, “lipstick index”, “streaming services during recession”, and other specific names for a particular topic; keywords were often followed by “economics” or “recession” to narrow down relevant sources. Some keywords were informed by online pages describing interesting indicators or studies (Kelly, 2023; Idrees, 2022) and by communication with economics researcher Dr. Blakeney (A. Blakeney, personal communication, February 23, 2026). As of yet, my school’s administration has not sought disciplinary action over my search queries on school Wi-Fi, such as “stripper index”, “porn consumption during recessions”, and “hot wasian men near me”. Academic sources referenced come from unbiased, peer-reviewed papers published in journals to ensure accurate information.

Non-academic sources were obtained through various methods, including Googling individual pieces of information and watching the show itself. I was initially introduced to the show by Denys Tereshchenko, and access to the show itself was graciously provided by Shloak Shah.

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